

Network Delaware

Nathan Sanchez

Workshop Implementation Framework

I. Introduction

Something has gone quietly wrong in American civic education. Students learn about government, but they rarely practice it. They can name the three branches of power, identify their senator, and pass a civics exam. What most of them can't do is run a meeting, negotiate with a school board, analyze a power structure, or mobilize a group around a shared goal. The gap between civic knowledge and civic capacity isn't incidental. It's structural, and it carries real consequences for any democracy that depends on an active, informed citizenry.

The evidence points in one direction. The most recent National Assessment of Educational Progress Civics Assessment found that only 20% of eighth graders demonstrated proficiency, and more than one-third failed to reach even the basic benchmark (YIP Institute). A 2026 survey by CivicPulse of nearly 1,400 local government leaders found that 83% viewed K-12 schools as positive contributors to civic participation, yet enormous gaps separated impact from opportunity: youth-led town halls were considered highly valuable by 73% of respondents but available in only 8% of communities (K12 Dive). Research from the Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE) at Tufts University shows that young people without regular in-person community interaction are consistently less likely to vote, volunteer, or take part in civic life across all seventeen engagement measures studied (CIRCLE, 2025). These findings point toward a shared problem. The civic knowledge gap is real, but it's secondary to the civic participation gap, and neither one closes through classroom instruction alone. What young people need isn't more information about how government works. They need structured, repeated chances to practice civic agency: to make decisions, build coalitions, navigate conflict, and push against institutions that hold real power.

Network Delaware's strategy, *From Civic Learning to Civic Power*, names this directly. We are building a civics gym where we prepare individuals and partner groups to improve their skills and foster equitable civic change, and ground its work in the leadership development philosophy of Ella Baker, prioritizing people who develop other leaders rather than models that concentrate authority in a single voice (Network Delaware, "About Us"). That orientation toward distributed, multiplied civic capacity is what separates the Network Delaware model from conventional civic programming.

This paper develops a Delaware-ready workshop implementation framework designed to put that strategy into practice at the school and community level. It draws on three high-impact models: the Student Voices/Anoka Action Civics model, Justice University, and Kingian Nonviolence

training. The goal is to translate their strongest structural elements into a concrete, replicable workshop format. The framework follows a six-phase Civic Action Cycle (Learn, Analyze, Organize, Act, Teach Back, Reflect and Iterate), aligns with Network Delaware's Four Fronts and Eight Guiding Principles, and is designed to serve Delaware's full student and community population, including immigrant youth, Black and Brown students, multilingual families, and LGBTQIA+ participants.

The goal here isn't to produce a lesson plan. It's to produce a design document that a teacher, community organizer, after-school program coordinator, or LEA administrator could use to build lasting civic capacity, not as a one-time event but as a durable infrastructure for civic power in Delaware.

II. Theoretical and Policy Foundation

The Civic Action Cycle

At the center of this proposal is the Civic Action Cycle, a six-phase model adapted from action civics theory. It treats civic engagement as a recursive loop rather than a linear sequence of research followed by action. Learning and doing reinforce each other at every stage. The six phases are: Learn, Analyze, Organize, Act, Teach Back, Reflect, and Iterate.

Learn: Participants develop foundational knowledge about a specific civic issue and the power structures surrounding it. This isn't passive absorption of facts. It's active inquiry into who holds power, who gets affected, and what mechanisms actually exist for influence.

Analyze: Moves from information to diagnosis: identifying root causes, mapping stakeholders, and distinguishing between surface-level problems and underlying structural conditions.

Organize: Where most civic education programs break down. Participants must build collective strategy rather than individual plans. That means outreach, coalition-building, task division, and deliberation toward shared goals.

Act: Is the public-facing moment, whether a city council presentation, a community survey, a policy brief, or a direct action.

Teach Back: participants share what they've learned with peers, which both deepens their own understanding and spreads civic capacity across the community.

Reflect and Iterate: Closes the loop by honestly assessing what worked, what failed, what should be revised, and what the next cycle of action should address.

This model is grounded in research. CIRCLE's synthesis of action civics programs found that youth who participate in structured civic action, including issue research, collective strategy, and public presentation, demonstrate significantly stronger civic identity, efficacy, and long-term participation than peers who receive only classroom instruction (CIRCLE, "Building an Evidence-Based Practice of Action Civics"). Generation Citizen, which has implemented a

version of this cycle across many schools nationally, describes the approach as "action-oriented, standards-aligned, community-based, and student-centered," and its evaluations show consistent gains in civic knowledge, skills, and engagement when students are given real decision points rather than simulated ones (Generation Citizen, District Report).

Why Traditional Civic Education Falls Short

The standard model of civic education in American schools carries three persistent weaknesses: it treats civic knowledge as an endpoint rather than a foundation; it centers individual participation over collective organizing; and it offers no framework for navigating conflict, power, or institutional resistance.

On the first point, the evidence is clear. Students who score well on civics assessments are more than twice as likely to understand why political participation matters, but that understanding rarely translates into action on its own (YIP Institute). Knowing how a bill becomes a law tells a student nothing about how to get a bill introduced, who to call, how to build a coalition, or what to do when an elected official ignores their concerns. The knowledge is real; it's just insufficient.

On the second point, researchers have found that civic education programs that include student voice and self-directed project design produce significantly stronger outcomes across multiple dimensions of civic attitude, including political engagement and tolerance, compared to programs where students are recipients rather than agents (Niemi and Junn, as cited in CIRCLE). Most school-based programs, though, still center on individual research and individual presentation over collective strategy and shared accountability.

The third weakness may be the most consequential for Delaware's goals. Without training in conflict navigation, power analysis, and nonviolent strategy, young people who hit institutional resistance, whether from a dismissive school board, a deflecting official, or a hostile community member, have no framework for responding. They either disengage or escalate. Neither builds durable civic power. That's the gap that Kingian Nonviolence training and Justice University's organizing curriculum are specifically built to address.

III. Comparative Model Analysis

Three models form the evidentiary base for this framework. Rather than treating each one separately, this section synthesizes their structural strengths and design gaps as they bear on the Delaware context.

Student Voices and the Anoka Action Civics Model

The Student Voices curriculum, studied extensively in Philadelphia high schools and replicated through the Anoka civic engagement model, stands as one of the most rigorously documented examples of action civics producing measurable civic outcomes. A study in the *American Journal of Political Science* examined Student Voices implementation across twenty-two high schools and found that specific program activities, particularly public presentation and community partner interaction, were the primary drivers of gains in civic knowledge and engagement (Kahne and Middaugh). The Anoka model builds on this by running students through a full cycle: team-based issue research, consultation with a community partner, peer presentation, and a final presentation to the Anoka City Council.

The structural strengths here are real. Students engage with an actual civic authority rather than a simulated one. The process demands deliberation and consensus, because the class has to agree on a shared issue and agenda before presenting publicly. The community partner meeting gives students firsthand exposure to institutional relationships and professional civic discourse. And the peer presentation functions as an internal teach-back that prepares students for the external advocacy that follows.

Its limitations for Delaware are worth naming honestly. There's no explicit training in strategic nonviolence, power analysis, or conflict navigation built into the model. If a student presents to a city council and gets a dismissive or bureaucratic response, which happens regularly, there's no curriculum for processing that experience or figuring out what to do next. The model also leans on having a civic authority willing to show up and engage, which isn't guaranteed in all Delaware contexts. It's strongest as a school-based model and doesn't transfer cleanly to community or after-school settings without deliberate adaptation.

Justice University

The Gathering for Justice's Justice University model is the most explicitly power-building of the three. Launched in 2014 as a training series for youth in New York and California and later expanded nationally, Justice University integrates organizing, leadership development, direct action, Kingian Nonviolence, know-your-rights education, violence reduction, de-escalation, and healing into a single cohesive training curriculum (The Gathering for Justice). Its defining structural feature is the train-the-trainer pipeline: in the model's original design, senior students who completed the training then trained incoming students, turning participants into facilitators and creating a self-sustaining leadership structure.

For Delaware's purposes, this model contributes three things the Anoka model lacks. It centers on collective strategy rather than individual or team presentation, so participants don't just research an issue; they build a campaign. It integrates nonviolence and de-escalation as civic tools rather than treating them as a separate subject. And the train-the-trainer structure is

intentionally designed to create civic multipliers, people who expand the movement's capacity by developing others.

The model's limitations are practical rather than conceptual. It was designed for community organizing contexts, not classrooms, which means some content, including direct action training, requires careful framing in school settings. The customized curriculum structure also means replication depends on qualified facilitators who understand both the organizing content and the youth development context. Without that investment, the model risks being watered down into a motivational session rather than a genuine capacity-building program.

Kingian Nonviolence Training

The Kingian Nonviolence curriculum, co-authored by civil rights leader Dr. Bernard LaFayette Jr. and David Jehnsen and delivered through both the Connecticut-based Center for Nonviolence and Peace Studies and The King Center Institute, provides the philosophical and strategic foundation that the other two models need but don't supply. The core two-day training covers the Six Principles of Nonviolence, the Six Steps for organizing a nonviolent campaign, conflict analysis, de-escalation, and a historical grounding in the Civil Rights Movement (Connecticut Center for Nonviolence and Peace Studies). The training-of-trainers pathway requires a minimum of fifty hours and certifies participants to co-facilitate the core curriculum.

What sets this model apart is that it treats nonviolence not as passivity but as an active strategy. Participants learn to analyze conflict types and levels, read the dynamics of a confrontation, and select from a toolkit of nonviolent responses that can shift power without escalating harm. This is precisely what action civics programs are missing when students run into institutional resistance.

For Delaware implementation, the most scalable element is the compact two-day core training, which can serve as a prerequisite for student leadership cohorts or as a facilitator development module. The fifty-hour training-of-trainers pathway is the mechanism for building durable facilitation capacity at the school or community level. The main barrier is the need for qualified lead trainers upfront, which means early implementation must rely on external facilitator partnerships before internal capacity can grow.

Comparative Model Assessment

These three models address distinct but complementary needs. The Anoka/Student Voices model provides the institutional access structure: the mechanism for engaging real civic authorities. Justice University provides the organizing architecture: the framework for collective strategy, campaign design, and leadership multiplication. Kingian Nonviolence provides the conflict

infrastructure: the tools for navigating institutional resistance, managing power dynamics, and sustaining disciplined collective action.

A framework drawing on only one or two of these will be incomplete. The Anoka model without nonviolence training produces civic participation without power. Justice University without institutional access produces organizing without leverage. Kingian Nonviolence, without a specific civic action context, produces philosophy without practice. The integration of all three is the design premise of the Delaware-Ready Civic Power Workshop proposed in the next section.

IV. Workshop Design Framework

The Delaware-Ready Civic Power Workshop has a multi-session structure with a single-session entry point. The 90-minute standalone session works as a pilot, a recruitment tool, or an orientation for a longer engagement. The full format is a six-session arc over six to eight weeks, designed to carry participants through the complete Civic Action Cycle from issue identification to public action to teach-back and reflection. Both formats share the same facilitation model and core activities; the multi-session format extends the time available for each phase and adds structured practice between sessions.

Facilitation Model

The workshop uses a hybrid facilitation model in which an adult or experienced peer facilitator manages the opening and closing, while students or community participants lead the core activity blocks. This is a deliberate design choice grounded in research showing that civic outcomes are stronger when youth hold genuine leadership roles in the program rather than being directed through it (Niemi and Junn; Generation Citizen, District Report). In practice, the facilitator opens the session, introduces the framework, and tracks time, while youth co-facilitators run the issue-mapping, power analysis, and strategy-building segments.

The model also includes a designated observer-analyst role for advanced participants who have completed the workshop at least once and are working toward becoming lead facilitators. Observer-analysts take notes on facilitation decisions, group dynamics, and strategic choices, then debrief with the lead facilitator after each session. This is the first tier of the train-the-trainer pipeline.

90-Minute Single Session Format

Opening: Power Mapping Introduction (15 minutes). The session begins with a grounding exercise in which participants identify one decision that affected their life in the past month and map who made it. The facilitator introduces the power map as a tool for visualizing who holds

formal and informal authority over a given issue. This grounds civic power in participants' actual experience and sets up the analytical work that follows.

Learn and Analyze: Issue Identification and Power Analysis (30 minutes). Participants work in small groups to identify a community issue they care about, then map the power structures around it using a basic stakeholder grid: who has decision-making authority, who is affected, who are potential allies, and who represents institutional resistance. Groups share their maps in a five-minute rapid-fire round designed to build the habit of concise, structured civic communication.

Organize: Collective Strategy Sprint (20 minutes). The full group selects one issue from the maps through a structured consensus process, not a vote, and builds a collective first-step strategy. This means identifying one achievable action, the body or person it targets, the specific ask, and who from the group would take the lead. The facilitator emphasizes that this is a strategy, not a wish list: it must be specific, targeted, and connected to a real decision-making process.

Act Preparation and Teach Back (20 minutes). Participants draft a 90-second civic statement presenting their ask to the relevant authority. Two or three groups present; peers offer structured feedback using a three-part protocol: what was clear, what was missing, and what would strengthen the argument. This peer feedback process is the teach-back mechanism within the 90-minute format.

Closing Reflection (5 minutes). The facilitator asks three questions: What surprised you? What would you do differently in a real meeting with this authority? And who in your life would benefit from knowing what you learned today? The third question plants the seed of the train-the-trainer pipeline: it invites participants to see themselves as civic educators before the session ends.

Multi-Session Format (6 Sessions over 6-8 Weeks)

Session 1: Learn. The opening session introduces the Civic Action Cycle, establishes group norms and a shared facilitation agreement, and begins issue identification. Participants conduct brief community listening between sessions, through interviews, informal surveys, or small-group conversations, to surface issues beyond their immediate perspective.

Session 2: Analyze. Power mapping is conducted in depth. Participants research their issue using primary sources, including local government records, school board agendas, and community organization reports, and build a comprehensive stakeholder map. A community partner, ideally

a local organizer or civic official, attends this session to give direct feedback on participants' analysis and share their own experience navigating the relevant power structures.

Session 3: Organize and Nonviolence Foundation. This session introduces the Six Steps of Kingian Nonviolence as an organizing framework, then asks participants to apply them to their specific issue. The session includes a role-play in which one group plays an institutional representative who resists the participants' ask, and participants practice de-escalation and strategic response using Kingian tools. The nonviolence and conflict navigation content is embedded in the organizing phase rather than treated as a separate topic.

Session 4: Strategy and Campaign Design. Participants develop a full campaign strategy: issue statement, theory of change, specific ask, target institution, stakeholder map, action timeline, and a contingency plan if the initial action draws no response. Groups present their strategies to peers for structured feedback. The facilitator introduces the concept of civic leverage: the difference between an ask a decision-maker can safely ignore and an ask tied to institutional accountability, public visibility, or political cost.

Session 5: Act. Participants carry out their civic action. Depending on available institutional relationships, this could mean presenting to a school board committee, delivering a community survey to a council member, organizing a community listening session, or submitting a formal policy recommendation. The facilitator and observer-analysts are present but don't intervene during the action. The group documents what happened and how the institution responded.

Session 6: Teach Back and Reflect and Iterate. The final session has two parts. In the first half, participants design and deliver a thirty-minute teach-back workshop for a new audience, whether peers, younger students, family members, or community members who weren't part of the original cohort. In the second half, the group debriefs the full arc honestly: what they learned, what they'd do differently, what institutional relationship they want to continue, and who from the group is ready to step into a co-facilitator role in the next cycle. Participants who opt into the facilitator pathway begin observer-analyst work in the next cohort's sessions.

V. Implementation Strategy

A workshop model that lives only on paper has limited value. The real test is whether it can move from design to practice across diverse institutional environments, absorb variation in staffing and resources, and sustain itself over time without constant external support. This section addresses how the Delaware-Ready Civic Power Workshop can be deployed statewide.

Integration into K-12 Curriculum

The most natural entry points for school-based implementation are high school government, social studies, and capstone courses, along with any existing service-learning requirements. Delaware Governor Matt Meyer's March 2026 proclamation designating a statewide Civic Learning Week reflects growing executive-level support for civic education, and the Delaware Civics Education Coalition represents an organized constituency that can advocate for curriculum integration at the state level (League of Women Voters of Delaware). That political moment should be treated as an opening for LEA-level policy work, not just a celebratory one.

At the classroom level, the six-session format aligns naturally with a semester elective or a capstone unit in a government course. The 90-minute session can be piloted as a guest workshop or advisory enrichment at virtually any grade level above middle school. For younger students, a simplified version of the power-mapping exercise, focused on school-level decisions rather than city or county governance, is developmentally appropriate and can build civic habits before students encounter formal civic education requirements.

After-School and Community-Based Implementation

After-school programs, youth development organizations, and community centers offer real advantages over school-based implementation: fewer political neutrality constraints, more flexibility in content and facilitation style, and participants who are often more self-selected and motivated. The workshop framework functions in either setting without structural modification.

For after-school implementation, the key adaptation is pacing. Sessions don't need to follow a weekly calendar; some cohorts will move faster, and the community listening component can be more expansive when participants aren't bound by the school day. For community-based implementation, the institutional target in the Act phase shifts from school board or municipal council to whatever authority is most relevant to the community's specific priorities, whether a county planning board, a public housing authority, a transit agency, or a state office.

Network Delaware's existing Organizing Fellowship and community coaching infrastructure provides a natural partnership channel for community-based implementation. Organizations that have already built civic engagement programming through the Network can integrate this workshop framework into their existing work rather than building from scratch.

LEA-Level Considerations

For Local Education Agencies, the main design questions are curriculum alignment, teacher training, and institutional partnership management. On curriculum alignment, the workshop framework maps to Delaware's social studies standards and to the C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards, which emphasizes inquiry and civic engagement as assessment targets.

LEAs that have adopted capstone projects as graduation requirements can position the six-session format as the vehicle through which students fulfill that requirement.

Teacher training is the more complex challenge. Most teachers who came through traditional social studies certification programs haven't been trained as civic organizers or action civics facilitators. The professional development investment required to prepare teachers for this work is real, and it shouldn't be undersold to school administrators. Teacher preparation should include at a minimum a one-day orientation, participation in a full mock session as a student, and ongoing coaching from a qualified facilitator during the first implementation cycle.

Institutional partnership management, meaning the work of securing and sustaining relationships with school boards, city councils, and community organizations that will serve as the Act-phase audience, is the most fragile element of school-based implementation. Partnerships built on personal relationships tend to fall apart when staff turn over. The framework addresses this by making the community partner role formal and named in the session structure rather than informal and improvised, which creates a documented relationship more likely to survive personnel changes.

Staffing and Facilitator Training

The minimum staffing requirement for a single cohort is one lead facilitator with action civics experience and one co-facilitator who has completed the workshop as a participant. As the leadership pipeline matures, the co-facilitator role can be filled by Tier Two participants in the observer-analyst phase, meaning staffing costs should decrease with each cohort cycle as internal capacity grows.

Lead facilitator training should include: the full Kingian Nonviolence core training (approximately 16 hours), a facilitated review of action civics research and the Civic Action Cycle framework (approximately 4 hours), and two supervised facilitation practicums with feedback from a senior facilitator (approximately 8 to 10 hours). Total initial training investment per lead facilitator is roughly 30 hours, which is comparable to the Justice University training-of-trainers model and is achievable as a summer institute or spread across a semester.

Timeline and Scalability

A realistic statewide rollout would move through three phases. Phase One (Year 1) focuses on piloting the workshop in three to five schools or community organizations across Delaware's three counties, with at least one rural, one suburban, and one urban site. The goal of Phase One is documentation, not scale: capturing what works, what doesn't, and what adaptations the Delaware context requires.

Phase Two (Years 2 to 3) uses the pilot documentation to refine the curriculum, trains a cohort of fifteen to twenty lead facilitators from both school and community settings, and expands to ten to fifteen implementation sites. This phase should also establish a statewide facilitator learning community, a regular gathering for lead facilitators to share practice, troubleshoot challenges, and identify emerging leaders for Tier Three.

Phase Three (Years 3 to 5) activates the full leadership pipeline: Tier Three participants leading new cohorts, the facilitator learning community operating as peer support and quality assurance, and LEA partnerships producing structured civic action capstones at the district level. At scale, the workshop should be self-sustaining, with new lead facilitators developing faster than existing ones cycle out, and institutional partnerships maintained through documented relationship protocols rather than individual champions.

VI. Equity, Accessibility, and Risk Mitigation

A civic education framework that doesn't explicitly name who it might exclude isn't a universal framework. It's a framework designed for the most advantaged participants, with everyone else adapted in afterward. This section addresses the populations for whom standard civic education models most consistently fail, and the specific design features built to serve them from the start.

Immigrant and Mixed-Status Families

For families in which some or all members are undocumented or hold mixed immigration status, conventional civic education carries real risks. Being visible in a public civic context, presenting to a city council, leading a community meeting, or being quoted in a local story can raise legitimate safety concerns that have nothing to do with civic confidence or knowledge. The framework addresses this in three ways. First, the Act phase allows multiple participation modes: not every participant needs to be the public spokesperson. Students can contribute through research, visual design, writing, logistics, and coaching without being publicly exposed. Second, the know-your-rights component drawn from the Justice University model should be standard in facilitator preparation, so facilitators can answer direct questions about civic participation and legal exposure. Third, the framework should never treat public presentation as the only measure of full participation. Civic capacity includes the ability to organize, research, strategize, and support, and all of it can be exercised without public visibility.

Black and Brown Youth

Research consistently shows that Black and Brown youth face higher barriers to civic participation and are more likely to experience civic institutions, including schools, as spaces of

surveillance and control rather than empowerment (CIRCLE, 2025). A workshop that asks young people of color to engage institutional authorities without first acknowledging those dynamics can reinforce rather than disrupt them. The Kingian Nonviolence component addresses this directly: the Civil Rights Movement history embedded in the curriculum places civic action within a tradition of Black-led, collective, disciplined resistance, which is both historically accurate and pedagogically meaningful for students who may not see themselves in mainstream civics textbooks. The power-mapping exercise also makes structural racism visible as a civic reality rather than treating it as background noise, which positions participants as analysts of power rather than objects of it.

Hispanic and Latino Communities

Delaware has a significant and growing Hispanic and Latino population, concentrated in New Castle County but present in agricultural communities across Sussex County as well. Civic barriers for these communities include language access, documentation concerns, and a civic education system that rarely reflects Latino civic traditions or histories. The workshop framework should include materials in Spanish, and facilitators should be trained to run sessions bilingually or to find community members who can provide real-time interpretation rather than written translation after the fact. Issue identification in Latino communities frequently surfaces priorities around housing, labor rights, school access, and agricultural worker protections that aren't well-served by civics curricula focused narrowly on electoral participation.

Disabled Students

Multiple participation pathways aren't optional accommodations; they're design requirements. The workshop uses visual tools (power maps, stakeholder grids), verbal tools (civic statements, peer feedback), written tools (campaign strategy documents), and physical tools (role-play, community listening). This multi-modal design means that students with different cognitive, sensory, and physical profiles can contribute meaningfully without requiring individual modification of every session. Facilitation training should include basic universal design for learning principles, and lead facilitators should do an accessibility assessment before each cohort to identify any specific adaptations needed.

LGBTQIA+ Youth

LGBTQIA+ students face particular risks in civic participation. They're more likely to experience community isolation, less likely to spend time in-person with community members, and more likely to encounter hostile institutional environments (CIRCLE, 2025; Trevor Project). Safety has to be a design prerequisite, not an afterthought. Group norms established in Session 1 should explicitly name respect for identity and pronoun use. The community partner for Session

2 should ideally include at least one organization with a demonstrated commitment to LGBTQIA+ inclusion. And the issue identification process shouldn't predefine what counts as civic: students who identify LGBTQIA+ rights, anti-discrimination policy, or school climate as their issue are engaging exactly the kind of power analysis this framework is designed to support.

Research from the Trevor Project's 2023 National Survey on LGBTQ Youth Mental Health found that civic engagement correlates with better mental health outcomes among LGBTQIA+ young people, and that participation in school-based Gay-Straight Alliances is positively associated with broader civic engagement and sense of agency (Trevor Project; Poteat et al.). These findings support the case that inclusive civic education isn't a political concession; it's a mechanism for building civic capacity in a population that's both civically motivated and structurally underserved.

Multilingual Families

Language accessibility should be built into every implementation, not added in response to a complaint. Session materials should be available in English, Spanish, and Haitian Creole, which are the three most widely spoken languages in Delaware. Facilitators should be trained to recognize when language is a barrier to participation and to adapt, through partners, interpretation, or visual tools, rather than proceeding as though comprehension can be assumed.

VII. Limitations and Design Risks

No workshop framework operates without friction. Honest identification of the risks is part of sound implementation planning.

Institutional Resistance

The most predictable source of resistance will come from school administrators and LEA officials concerned about political neutrality. Action civics, particularly when it involves students presenting to real civic authorities about real community issues, will sometimes be read as advocacy programming rather than civic education. That concern isn't entirely misplaced: the line between civic education and political organizing is genuinely contested, and facilitators who are careless about framing can inadvertently confirm those concerns.

The most effective response isn't to strip controversy from the program; it's to make the framework's nonpartisan design explicit and visible. The workshop doesn't take positions on parties, candidates, or ideological questions. It teaches participants to identify their own community priorities, analyze the structures around them, and practice civic communication with whatever relevant authority exists. That's civic education in the traditional sense, and it can be

defended as such to skeptical administrators. Facilitators should be ready to explain that distinction clearly and point to the research base supporting action civics as an educational approach.

Political Neutrality Concerns in School Settings

Related to institutional resistance but distinct from it is the risk that teachers and facilitators, in an effort to sidestep political controversy, strip the workshop of its power analysis content and reduce it to a discussion of civic procedures. A power map that can't name structural racism, economic inequality, or institutional accountability isn't a power map. It's a stakeholder list. The framework should include explicit guidance for facilitators on the distinction between partisan advocacy, which means naming parties and candidates and promoting specific ideological positions, and structural civic analysis, which means identifying who holds power, how it's exercised, and what mechanisms exist for accountability. The latter is both appropriate and necessary for genuine civic education.

Resource Constraints

The workshop requires a trained lead facilitator, institutional partnership management, and time for session preparation and debrief. In resource-constrained schools, which includes most Delaware schools serving high proportions of low-income students, students of color, and English language learners, the opportunity cost of dedicating staff time to this kind of programming is real. The three-phase rollout and the leadership pipeline are designed specifically to reduce long-term resource dependence, but the initial investment isn't trivial and shouldn't be presented to school administrators as though it were.

Network Delaware should plan to provide staffing support, facilitation resources, and institutional partnership coordination during the pilot and early expansion phases. Schools that can't yet sustain the program independently shouldn't be excluded from Phase One. They should be prioritized as the sites where external support investment is most needed and most consequential.

Risk of Symbolic Participation

The most insidious risk in any civic education program is performative participation: students who go through the motions of civic engagement without any real connection to decision-making. A presentation to a city council where no one on the council has read the materials in advance, in a public comment slot where follow-up is impossible, teaches students something about civic institutions. But not the right thing. It teaches them that their voice is

welcomed symbolically and ignored substantively, which suppresses future participation rather than building it.

The framework addresses this by requiring genuine institutional access rather than symbolic access. The community partner in Session 2 must be someone with actual standing to offer feedback and open doors. The Act phase must involve a real decision-making process, not a ceremonial audience. And the Reflect and Iterate phase must be honest about what the action accomplished and what it didn't, rather than treating the act of showing up as though it were the same thing as building power.

VIII. Recommendations

Five recommendations follow from this analysis for Network Delaware's consideration as it develops the From Civic Learning to Civic Power implementation strategy.

First, launch the workshop as a pilot in at least three geographically and demographically distinct sites before attempting statewide rollout. New Castle, Kent, and Sussex counties have different civic landscapes, different institutional relationships, and different community demographics. Testing the framework across those differences will produce more useful documentation than a single-site pilot, regardless of how well that one site goes. Prioritize at least one site serving a majority of students of color and at least one with a significant immigrant or multilingual population.

Second, treat facilitator training as the primary infrastructure investment, not curriculum development. A well-trained facilitator can adapt materials; polished materials can't compensate for a facilitator who isn't prepared. The 30-hour training pathway described in Section V should be developed as a summer institute and offered annually, with Network Delaware coordinating the Kingian Nonviolence component through partnership with the Connecticut Center for Nonviolence and Peace Studies or The King Center Institute.

Third, build institutional partnerships before the first cohort begins, not after. The most common failure point in action civics programs is the Act phase: students prepare a civic action and then discover there's no real audience, or the audience is purely ceremonial. Network Delaware should cultivate formal Memoranda of Understanding with willing school boards, city and county councils, and state agency offices that commit to providing genuine engagement time and written responses to student cohorts. These partnerships need to be documented at the organizational level so they don't collapse when individual staff turn over.

Fourth, develop an equity audit tool for facilitators to use before each cohort. The tool should prompt facilitators to assess who in their participant group may face participation barriers, what

accessibility adaptations are needed, whether materials are available in all relevant languages, whether the institutional partner has an inclusive track record, and whether the issue identification process has been structured to surface priorities from the most marginalized participants rather than defaulting to the concerns of the most vocal.

Fifth, connect the workshop to Delaware's existing civic infrastructure rather than positioning it as a replacement for what's already there. The Delaware Civics Education Coalition, the League of Women Voters of Delaware, the Center for Civic Education, and existing service-learning programs in Delaware schools all represent potential allies and implementation channels. A framework that presents itself as the best approach rather than a contribution to a broader ecosystem will generate unnecessary resistance. Network Delaware's comparative advantage is in organizing and leadership development, not in displacing programs that already serve students well.

IX. Conclusion

The shift from civic learning to civic power isn't a slogan. It describes a real developmental arc: from acquiring knowledge about democratic institutions to building the capacity to act within them, collectively, strategically, and with discipline. That arc doesn't close in a single semester, a single workshop, or a single election cycle. It closes through repeated practice, structured reflection, and the deliberate expansion of civic capacity from individuals to cohorts to communities.

The Delaware-Ready Civic Power Workshop is designed to accelerate that arc. By bringing together the institutional access structure of the Anoka Action Civics model, the organizing and leadership infrastructure of Justice University, and the conflict navigation and strategic nonviolence foundation of Kingian Nonviolence training, the framework offers something no single model provides on its own: a complete civic formation experience that moves participants from knowledge to analysis to strategy to action to teaching back and starting again.

Delaware is, in meaningful ways, well-positioned for this work. It's small enough that statewide coordination is achievable. It has a growing civic education coalition, executive-level support for civic learning, and a diverse population whose communities have everything to gain from genuine civic power. What it doesn't yet have is the infrastructure to move young people reliably from learning to power. This framework is a proposal for building that infrastructure: deliberately, equitably, and with the kind of multiplied leadership that Network Delaware's model has always believed is possible.

Works Cited

Carnegie Corporation of New York and CivicPulse. Polarization in America: Survey of Local Government, Survey III. CivicPulse, 2026, www.carnegie.org/publications/polarization-in-america-survey-of-local-government-survey-iii/.

Center for Civic Education. C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards. Center for Civic Education, 2013, www.civiced.org.

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "Youth Are Taking Civic Action, But Need Opportunities and Support to Overcome Socioeconomic Barriers." CIRCLE at Tufts University, 30 Sept. 2025, circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/youth-are-taking-civic-action-need-opportunities-and-support-overcome-socioeconomic.

Connecticut Center for Nonviolence (CTCN). Kingian Nonviolence Trainings. Connecticut Center for Nonviolence, 2025, ctnonviolence.org/programs/kingian-nonviolence-trainings/.

Council of State Governments. Civics Education: Policy Brief. The Council of State Governments, May 2022, web.csg.org/csghealthystates/wp-content/uploads/sites/23/2022/05/Healthy-States-National-Task-Force-Policy-Brief-Civics-Education.pdf.

Gathering for Justice, The. Programs. The Gathering for Justice, 2020, www.gatheringforjustice.org/programs.

Generation Citizen. Action Civics in School Districts: District Report. Generation Citizen, 2017, cms.generationcitizen.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/GC-District-Report-170721_final.pdf.

Gingold, Jessica. "Building an Evidence-Based Practice of Action Civics: The Current State of Assessments and Recommendations for the Future." CIRCLE Working Paper No. 78, Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement, Aug. 2013, circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/building-case-action-civics.

Kahne, Joseph, and Ellen Middaugh. "Democracy for Some: The Civic Opportunity Gap in High School." CIRCLE Working Paper No. 59, Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement, 2008, www.civicsurvey.org/publications/democracy-for-some-civic-opportunity-gap.

League of Women Voters of Delaware. Delaware Civics Education Proclamation by Governor Meyer. League of Women Voters of Delaware, 14 Mar. 2026, my.lwv.org/delaware/article/delaware-civics-education-proclamation-governor-meyer.

Network Delaware. "About Us." Network Delaware, thenetworkde.org/about.

Niemi, Richard G., and Jane Junn. Civic Education: What Makes Students Learn. Yale University Press, 1998.

Poteat, V. Paul, et al. "Gay-Straight Alliance Involvement and Youths' Participation in Civic Engagement and Political Action." *Journal of Research on Adolescence*, vol. 28, no. 2, 2018, pp. 433-448, pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/29805190/.

Trevor Project, The. "Civic Engagement and Mental Health Among LGBTQ Young People." The Trevor Project, 6 Oct. 2025, www.thetrevorproject.org/research-briefs/civic-engagement-and-mental-health-among-lgbtq-young-people/.

YIP Institute. "When Civic Education Fails, Democracy Follows." YIP Institute, 18 Jan. 2026, yipinstitute.org/article/when-civic-education-fails-democracy-follows.